

Module 2: Agents — You're Not an NPC (You Make Choices That Matter)

Learning Objectives

1. Understand what it means to be an **agent** — someone who has goals, makes predictions, and takes actions to shape their world.
2. Recognize that everyone around you is also an agent with their **own goals and models**, which is why people sometimes clash.
3. Learn the difference between acting on **autopilot** and making intentional choices.

Introduction

In video games, there are two kinds of characters: player characters (PCs) and non-player characters (NPCs). NPCs just follow their programming. They walk the same path, say the same lines, react the same way every time. Player characters? They make real choices. They explore. They strategize. They decide what happens next.

Here's the thing: in real life, you get to choose whether you act like a PC or an NPC. Most of the time, you're on autopilot — following routines, going with the flow, reacting without thinking. But the moment you stop, consider your options, and make a deliberate choice? That's when you become a true **agent**.

An agent isn't just someone who does stuff. An agent is someone who has a **model of how the world works**, uses that model to **predict what will happen**, and then **acts** to make things go the way they want. And that's you. Let's talk about what that really means.

Key Concepts

1. What Makes You an Agent?

An **agent** is anything that senses its environment, has internal goals, and takes actions to achieve those goals. You do this constantly.

When you're deciding whether to raise your hand in class, here's what's happening in your brain: You have a **goal** (answer the question, or maybe just look like you're paying attention). You have a **model** of the situation (the teacher calls on people who raise their hands, other students might judge you if you're wrong). You **predict** what might happen (you might get it right and feel good, or get it wrong and feel embarrassed). Then you **decide** — hand up or hand down.

All of that happens in about two seconds, but it's an incredibly sophisticated process. You're not just reacting — you're running a mental simulation and choosing based on the results.

2. Everyone Else Is an Agent Too

Here's where it gets really interesting — and sometimes really frustrating. Every person around you is also an agent with their own goals, their own model of how things work, and their own predictions.

When you and your friend disagree about where to sit at lunch, it's not because one of you is right and the other is wrong. It's because you have **different models**. Maybe you want to sit near the window because you value quiet. Your friend wants to sit in the middle because they value being part of the action. Neither model is broken — they're just optimizing for different things.

Understanding this is a social superpower. When someone does something that seems weird or annoying, instead of just getting frustrated, you can ask: "What's their model? What are they predicting? What are they trying to achieve?" It doesn't mean you have to agree with them, but it does help you understand them.

3. Autopilot vs. Intentional Mode

You can't be fully intentional about everything — you'd be exhausted by lunchtime. Your brain puts most of your day on autopilot (brushing teeth, walking to class, scrolling your phone) to save energy for the big stuff.

The trick is knowing **when to switch from autopilot to intentional mode**. Autopilot is fine for routine stuff. But for important decisions — choosing friends, responding to conflict, deciding how to spend your time — you want to be a fully aware agent.

A simple test: Before you do something important, ask yourself, "Am I choosing this, or am I just doing it because it's what I always do?" If it's autopilot, take a breath and switch to intentional mode.

Try It!

Agent Observation Journal. For one day, notice three moments where you switched from autopilot to making a deliberate choice. Write down: (1) What was the situation? (2) What were your options? (3) What did you predict would happen? (4) What did you choose, and why? Bonus: try to figure out someone else's model in a situation where you disagreed.

Summary

An **agent** is someone who has goals, builds mental models, makes predictions, and takes action. That's you — every single day. Everyone around you is also an agent with their own models, which explains why people sometimes see the same situation completely differently. The key skill is knowing when to switch from autopilot to intentional mode so you're actually choosing your path instead of just drifting. Coming up in the next module: **Perception** — how your brain gathers the information it uses to make all those predictions.